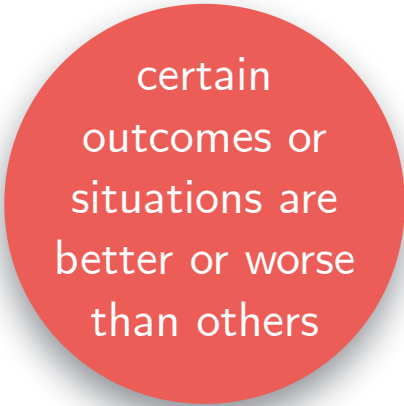




certain actions
are right or
wrong



certain
outcomes or
situations are
better or worse
than others

A solid green circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "certain people or lives are better or worse than others" is written in a white, sans-serif font, arranged in five lines.

certain
people or lives
are better or
worse than
others

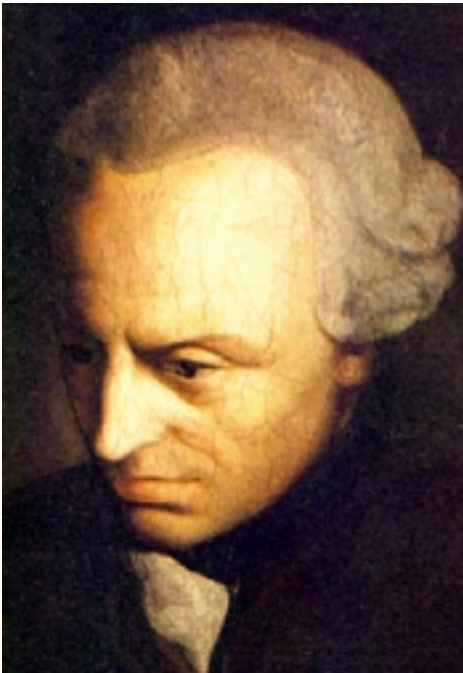
The consequentialist takes the goodness or badness of situations as fundamental, and tries to explain the others in terms of these. What would it look like if we took one of the other categories as most fundamental?

A **deontological** approach to what we ought to do takes facts about the rightness and wrongness of actions as basic, and does not try to explain the rightness or wrongness of actions in terms of the goodness or badness of the action's outcomes.

There are lots of different deontological theories. I'm going to briefly introduce you to one, which is based on the idea that people have certain basic **rights**. On this view, wrong actions are actions which violate someone's rights.

But what are rights, and which actions violate them?

One answer to this question was given by the 18th century German philosopher Immanuel Kant.



Kant thought that all human beings have dignity, and that this means that we all have the right not to be used as a way to satisfy the desires of others.

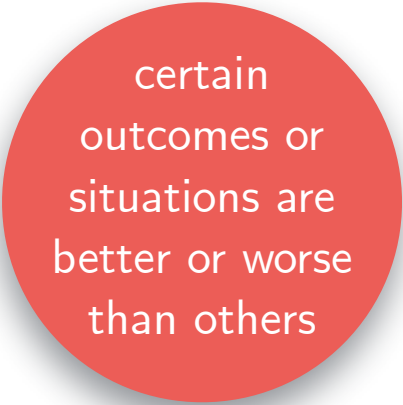
The second is that there are plenty of cases where there seems to be a moral obligation to do or not do something, even though, either way, no one is treating anyone else as a mere means. Let's consider three examples of this.

The second are cases of simple disregard. Suppose that I drive very quickly out of my neighborhood and run over a child. It does not seem that I used the child as a means to an end; but this was surely wrong.

The first are cases which involve no actions toward other human beings. Consider, for example, animal cruelty or environmental destruction. These actions involve treating no one as a mere means, but seem clearly wrong.



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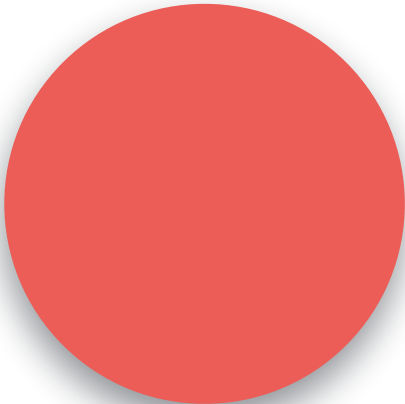
Our last approach takes as basic, neither the goodness or badness of situations nor the rightness or wrongness of actions, but the notion of a **good person** or **good human life**. This approach to our question is sometimes called 'virtue ethics.'

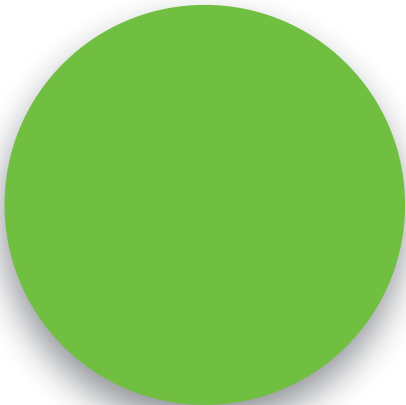
As with consequentialism and deontology, there are various different specific versions of virtue ethics. But as in those cases, I'll focus in on one, which is a version of a kind of theory called **perfectionism**. This kind of theory goes back to Aristotle.

According to this kind of theory, if you are deciding between X and Y, you don't ask which would lead to the best consequences, and don't ask which would accord with the moral rules, but instead ask which would lead to you leading the best overall life.

The qualities which would contribute to your life being a good one are called virtues.







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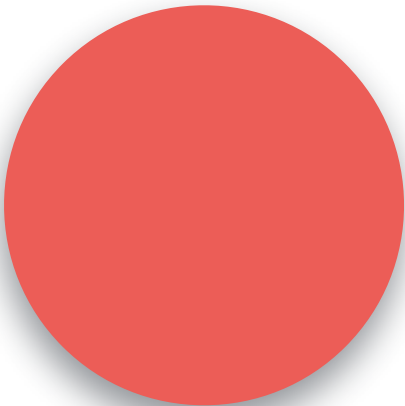
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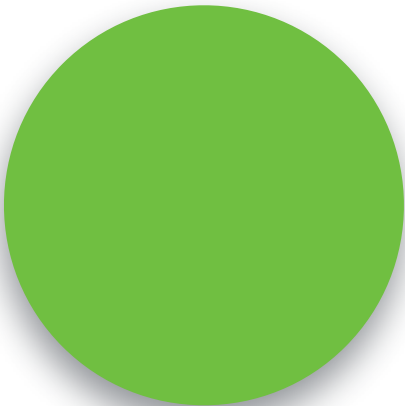
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Our last approach takes as basic, neither the goodness nor badness of situations nor

the success theory. Most of the issues that will come up would also

substitute accordingly.

apply to preference hedonism — so if you prefer that view, you can

In what follows, I'll set preference head on this to the side, and focus on

Here's a problem for the view that desires play the central role which

the success theory gives to them:

Consider this example. Knowing that you accept a Summative theory, I tell you that I am about to make your life go better. I shall inject you with an addictive drug. From now on, you will wake each morning with an extremely strong desire to have another injection of this drug. Having this desire will be in itself neither pleasant nor painful, but if the desire is not fulfilled within an hour it will then become very painful. This is no cause for concern, since I shall give you ample supplies of this drug. Every morning, you will be able at once to fulfil this desire. The injection, and its after-effects, would also be neither pleasant nor painful. You will spend the rest of your days as you do now.

Would it make your life go better to be injected with the addictive

drug?

morning. None of these are things that you want to do.

of the drug around, and will have to give yourself an injection every

Intuitively, no. You will always have to remember to have ample supplies

well. According to the success theory, taking the drug makes

On the other hand, if you take the drug, you will have a whole new

satisfied. But according to the success theory, having your desires —

morning of your life. And each of these extremely strong desires will be

your life go (much) better.

group of extremely strong desires: they desire to take the drug each

especially your very strong desires — satisfied if what makes your life go

relevantly like it.

This is of course a made up case. But there are real life cases which are



decides to get rid of this desire. Now when she comes to

time. So, knowing that her life goes on, she was able to

Violet is a softball player. Every time she comes to the

strongly held desires about her life are not met, Violet

the plate, does not desire to get a hit. She gets hits less

plate, she wants very badly to get a hit. But so far all is

often now; but here life is better, since new herds are

notified.

hard, and even the best players don't get hits most of the

posed by the case of Violet remains. This is brought out by the example

global theories, one might think that a problem with what like the one

But even after we introduce this distinctive and

of the grass-counter:

Consider the man that Rawls imagined who wants to spend his life counting the numbers of blades of grass in different lawns. Suppose that this man knows that he could achieve great progress if instead he worked in some especially useful part of Applied Mathematics. Though he could achieve such significant results, he prefers to go on counting blades of grass. On the Success Theory, if we allow this theory to cover all imaginable cases, it could be better for this person if he counted his blades of grass rather than achieving great and useful mathematical results.

Here the desire to spend his life counting blades of grass is a global

desire. So even though the global success theory has to say that the man has a

better hunting blades of grass than he would have achieving great

and useful things in mathematics.

One can have two different kinds of reactions to this case.

First, one might regard this result as unproblematic. If this is what the

counting blades of grass.

man wants to spend his life doing, then his best life genuinely is spent

On the other hand, one might regard this as a waste of a life. Counting



be a good life.

blades of grass is pointless; and a life spent doing pointless things can't

them to have the best life possible, and that you know that they desire

One way to bring out the second response is to imagine that the grass-

life as a grass-counter. Wouldn't you still hope that they moved on from

counter is someone you love — perhaps a child. Suppose that you want

grass-counting at some point?

if you think this, then this would be a reason to abandon the success

theory in favor of what Parfit calls an objective list theory.

features. What gets on the list is not determined by what you want — it

certain features — the ones on the objective list of good-making

is something fixed independently of your desires.

An objective list theory says that a good life is one which contains

grass-courtwould have lived a better life by spending his time on

The objective list theorist can say that, despite his global desires, the

other pursuits.

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